

Entry

Public Relations: Discipline, Practice and Profession

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Definition

Public Relations (PR) is the strategic role of communication between an organization or public actor and the publics on whose recognition, trust and consent its operation depends. The field encompasses media relations, internal and employee communication, public affairs and government relations, crisis and reputation management, community relations and corporate social responsibility, investor relations, marketing communications, political communication, digital and platform engagement, and the communication of activist and non-governmental organizations. PR scholarship draws on sociology, political philosophy, organizational studies, rhetoric and media studies to examine how organizations construct, sustain and contest their legitimacy in the public sphere. The dominant theoretical framework of the late twentieth century, the Excellence Theory developed by James Grunig and colleagues, defined PR as the symmetrical management of relationships with strategic publics; the field has since broadened to include relational, dialogic, rhetorical, situational, contingent and critical approaches, alongside frameworks grounded in stakeholder theory, institutional analysis and emerging work on public legitimacy. Contemporary PR operates within a hybrid media environment shaped by digital platforms, algorithmic visibility, generative artificial intelligence and the structural erosion of institutional trust. It is simultaneously a professional industry of significant global economic scale and a contested civic function whose democratic role, ethical foundations and disciplinary boundaries remain the subject of active scholarly debate.

Keywords: public relations; strategic communication; excellence theory; stakeholders; public legitimacy; political public relations

1. Introduction

Public Relations is among the most pervasive and least understood functions of modern social life. It is invoked to explain everything from a corporate apology after a product recall to the choreography of an election rally, from the daily routines of a hospital press officer to the curated presence of a head of state on a social platform. Few professional fields are so widely practiced, so consistently studied, and so persistently contested in their definition and democratic significance [1–3].

This entry maps Public Relations as both a field of practice and an academic discipline. It works through five questions: how the field came into being, how it has defined itself, which theoretical traditions organize scholarly debate, how it is practiced in its functional areas, and how it is being reshaped by the digital and algorithmic conditions of the present [4–6].

The entry does not settle the controversies over the scope and purpose of the field. It identifies what counts as established knowledge and where the live disagreements remain.



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Public Relations is too central to the working of contemporary organizations and democracies, and too unstable as a discipline, to be reduced to a single school. To understand it requires holding the managerial, relational, rhetorical and political dimensions in view at once [7,8].

While this entry maps the field's major traditions even-handedly, it also adopts a particular interpretive standpoint, which the reader should be able to recognize. Across its historical, conceptual and theoretical sections it reads Public Relations through the lens of legitimacy—the communicative process by which organizations and public actors earn, sustain, lose and repair the recognition, trust and consent on which their authority depends. This standpoint is offered not as a settled consensus but as one productive way of integrating the field's otherwise fragmented paradigms. Where the Excellence tradition centers managerial effectiveness and symmetry, the relational tradition the organization–public bond, the rhetorical tradition the contest of meaning, and the critical tradition the operation of power, the legitimacy perspective treats these as partial answers to a prior question: how the right to act and to be heard is publicly constituted. Section 4.7 develops this perspective as an emerging line of theory; the Conclusion returns to it as the entry's organizing synthesis.

2. Genesis and Historical Development

The history of Public Relations can be told in at least three registers: as a story of professional practice, as a story of disciplinary thought, and as a story of the social conditions that made an autonomous communication function necessary. The three stories overlap but do not coincide, and the field's recurring debates over its own origins are themselves part of its theoretical condition [9].

2.1. Rhetorical and Pre-Modern Antecedents

The persuasive management of public opinion is older than the discipline that came to name it. Classical rhetoric, codified by Aristotle in the fourth century BCE and developed by Cicero and Quintilian under the Roman Republic and early Empire, supplied the analytical vocabulary—ethos, pathos, logos, deliberative, forensic, epideictic—through which the public uses of speech were first systematized [10,11]. Medieval and early modern instances of organized public communication, from the papal *Sacra Congregatio de Propaganda Fide* established in 1622 to the pamphleteering of the English Civil War and the French Revolution, demonstrate that organized efforts to shape mass belief considerably predate the modern profession [12].

What separates these antecedents from modern Public Relations is not the existence of persuasive activity but the absence of a stable institutional form. PR as a discipline did not emerge from rhetoric but from the structural conditions that, by the late nineteenth century, made the routine management of organizational visibility a permanent requirement: industrial concentration, the rise in mass media, expanding suffrage, and the consolidation of regulatory and democratic publics capable of imposing reputational costs on organizations whose conduct they came to see as illegitimate [13,14].

2.2. United States Origins: From Press Agency to Counsel

The conventional historiography of the field locates the birth of modern Public Relations in the United States between the 1900s and the 1920s, against the backdrop of muckraking journalism, antitrust regulation, and growing public hostility toward large industrial corporations [15,16]. Ivy Lee, often cited as the first modern PR counsel, issued his Declaration of Principles in 1906 on behalf of the anthracite coal operators and subsequently advised the Pennsylvania Railroad and the Rockefeller interests after the Ludlow Massacre

of 1914. Lee's contribution was less a theoretical innovation than a methodological one: he insisted that organizational communication should rest on the disclosure of accurate information and on routine engagement with the press rather than on concealment [17].

The First World War produced the first large-scale demonstration that public opinion could be mobilized by the state. The Committee on Public Information (1917–1919), chaired by the journalist George Creel, coordinated an extensive propaganda apparatus—press releases, posters, films and the volunteer “Four Minute Men” speaker network—to build domestic support for the war effort. Creel's own retrospective account, *How We Advertised America* (1920), records both the ambition and the techniques of the campaign. For the history of Public Relations the Committee matters less for its methods than for its personnel and its legacy: it served as a training ground for a founding generation of practitioners—Edward Bernays among them—and it fixed, for the field's critics, the lasting association between organized persuasion and propaganda [18].

Edward Bernays, nephew of Sigmund Freud, is conventionally credited with giving the field its first systematic theory. *Crystallizing Public Opinion* (1923) and *Propaganda* (1928) framed PR as the engineering of consent grounded in an understanding of the psychological dynamics of mass publics. Bernays adopted the term “public relations counsel” and treated the activity as an applied social science. His campaigns, including the 1929 Torches of Freedom march that linked cigarette smoking to women's emancipation, are the period's evidence that opinion can be technically managed. In the standard historiography Bernays is regarded as the most theoretically ambitious of the founders, and as the figure to whom the discipline owes more than it has been comfortable acknowledging [19,20].

Arthur Page, vice president of AT&T from 1927 to 1946, formulated what became the institutional counterpart to Bernays's persuasive ambition. Page argued that the legitimacy of a large corporation depended on its public conduct rather than on its publicity, and that the function of corporate communication was therefore to ensure that the organization acted in ways that justified public trust. The propositions later codified by the Arthur W. Page Society as the Page Principles—“tell the truth”, “prove it with action”, “listen to the customer”, “manage for tomorrow”, “conduct public relations as if the whole company depends on it”, among others—were drawn from Page's published lectures and AT&T philosophy and have been continuously invoked as a counter-tradition within the field to the more instrumental Bernaysian inheritance [21,22].

2.3. European Trajectories

Public Relations developed along distinct trajectories in Europe. In Germany, the *Öffentlichkeitsarbeit* tradition, with antecedents in the press offices of the Wilhelmine state and the corporate communication functions of firms such as Krupp and Siemens, was reconstructed after 1945 under a strong influence of normative Habermasian thought, giving German-language scholarship a particular orientation toward the public sphere [23,24]. In the United Kingdom, the Institute of Public Relations (now the Chartered Institute of Public Relations, CIPR) was founded in 1948, drawing on wartime experience in the Ministry of Information and on a longer tradition of governmental public information work [25]. In France, Belgium and the Mediterranean countries, PR consolidated later and developed in close proximity to journalism, marketing, and political communication, with national variations that remain visible in contemporary professional structures [26].

The European trajectories are theoretically significant because they generated, comparatively early, a more politicized and more critical scholarship than the dominant American tradition. The work of Günter Bentele in Germany on public trust, of Jacquie L'Etang and Magda Pieczka in the United Kingdom on the ideology of the profession, and of authors associated with the European Public Relations Education and Research Association

(EUPRERA) consistently reframed PR as a phenomenon embedded in democratic and institutional structures, rather than as a managerial technique [27–29].

2.4. *Beyond the Euro-Atlantic Core: Latin American, African and Asian Trajectories*

Public Relations outside the Euro-Atlantic core has its own institutional histories, which the dominant historiography has only recently begun to integrate. Latin American PR scholarship, with significant traditions in Brazil, Mexico and Colombia, developed in close proximity to the field of communication studies and to popular communication traditions associated with Paulo Freire. The Brazilian tradition is particularly developed: Margarida Kunsch's planning-oriented and organizationally integrated approach to PR has shaped pedagogy and practice across Lusophone scholarship for over three decades [30], while Roberto Porto Simões's Political Theory of Public Relations formulated PR, as early as the 1980s and consolidated in the 1990s, as a political function of mediation of conflict between organizations and their publics—a framing that, on the reading advanced here, anticipates much of the contemporary legitimacy-oriented and critical reorientation of the field [31,32]. African PR scholarship, anchored institutionally by national associations in South Africa, Kenya, Nigeria and Ghana, has produced a substantial amount of the literature on PR in post-colonial and developmental contexts [33]. Asian PR consolidated rapidly from the 1990s onward, with strong traditions in Singapore, Malaysia, India, China, Japan and South Korea; the work of Krishnamurthy Sriramesh and colleagues on global and culturally grounded PR has been particularly influential in framing the comparative project, and the rapid institutional consolidation of PR in mainland China since the 1990s has generated its own distinct literature [34,35].

These traditions are not peripheral additions to a settled Anglo-American core; they have generated distinctive theoretical, ethical and institutional commitments that an adequate understanding of the field must integrate. The dominant historiography of the discipline has, since the 2010s, begun to acknowledge this plurality; the consolidation of comparative and global PR research is widely regarded as one of the most significant intellectual developments of the past decade.

2.5. *Post-War Professionalization and Disciplinary Consolidation*

The post-war decades saw the consolidation of PR as a professional industry on both sides of the Atlantic. National associations multiplied, codes of ethics were adopted, and university programs—initially in journalism schools, later in dedicated communication faculties—began to issue formal qualifications [36]. The International Public Relations Association (IPRA) was founded in 1955; the Public Relations Society of America (PRSA) had been established in 1947 from the merger of earlier bodies; the Global Alliance for Public Relations and Communication Management, an umbrella organization of national associations, was founded in 2000 [37].

Academic consolidation followed. The publication of Cutlip and Center's *Effective Public Relations* (first edition 1952) provided the field with its first widely adopted textbook and with the four-step process model—Research, Planning, Communication, Evaluation—that continues to organize professional pedagogy [38]. The launch of dedicated scholarly journals from the 1970s onward (*Public Relations Review*, 1975; *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 1989; *Public Relations Inquiry*, 2012) institutionalized research production and gave the field the bibliographic infrastructure required for sustained theoretical development [39].

2.6. *The Digital Transformation and the Algorithmic Turn*

The arrival of the World Wide Web in the mid-1990s and the rise in social platforms after 2004 transformed the operational conditions of Public Relations more profoundly than any preceding technological shift. The disintermediation of journalism, the collapse

of mass-audience monopolies, the rise in platform gatekeepers governed by algorithmic visibility, and the emergence of always-on news cycles displaced the press release and the press conference as the central instruments of professional work [40,41]. The 2010s added a further layer: the recognition that algorithmic curation, polarization, and disinformation had altered the structural conditions of the public sphere within which PR operates [42].

Generative artificial intelligence, particularly the diffusion of large language models from 2022 onward, has produced a further inflection. AI now routinely participates in content production, media monitoring, sentiment analysis, audience segmentation, and the simulation of stakeholder reactions, raising practical questions about authorship and authenticity as well as deeper questions about the human and democratic significance of communicative labor. The integration of generative AI into the daily routines of PR practice is at present the most active site of professional and scholarly attention [43–45].

3. Definitions and Conceptual Scope

There is no single accepted definition of Public Relations. The proliferation of competing formulations is itself a feature of the field. Heath and Coombs identified more than five hundred published definitions; Harlow's 1976 inventory, often cited, listed 472 [46,47]. The persistent definitional instability is not the symptom of a young discipline still searching for its terms. It reflects the structural fact that Public Relations describes a function performed under conditions that differ widely across organizational, political, cultural and technological contexts [48].

3.1. Major Professional Definitions

The Public Relations Society of America (PRSA) defines Public Relations, in its current formulation adopted in 2012, as “a strategic communication process that builds mutually beneficial relationships between organizations and their publics” [49]. The Chartered Institute of Public Relations (CIPR) defines it as “the discipline which looks after reputation, with the aim of earning understanding and support and influencing opinion and behavior” [50]. The Global Alliance Stockholm Accords (2010) describe PR as “the strategic management function that responsibly contributes to the establishment, maintenance, and strengthening of relationships between an organization and its strategic constituencies” [37]; the subsequent Melbourne Mandate (2012) extended this definition by calling on the profession to actively build a culture of listening and engagement and to contribute to the construction of value for both organizations and society [51]. These formulations converge on a small set of recurring elements: a strategic intent, a communicative process, a relational object, and a normative reference to mutuality or responsibility.

3.2. Academic Definitions and the Concept of Publics

Academic definitions tend to be more analytically demanding. Grunig and Hunt (1984) defined Public Relations as “the management of communication between an organization and its publics”, a formulation whose apparent simplicity conceals the disciplinary investment in two distinctions: between communication and other forms of organizational action, and between publics and other audience categories such as markets, masses or crowds [52] (p. 6). The concept of publics, in particular, carries a substantive theoretical load: it refers, after Dewey and Blumer, to social groupings that organize themselves in response to shared problems and that constitute themselves as agents of consequence through the communicative process [53,54].

Distinguishing publics from related categories is a defining concern of the field. The public is not the audience, which is an aggregate constituted by exposure to a message; nor the market, which is constituted by transactional intent; nor the crowd, which is constituted

by physical or symbolic co-presence. Publics are constituted by their relationship to a problem and by their communicative engagement with it, and it is this constitution that makes them the proper object of PR work [55,56].

3.3. Boundaries with Adjacent Fields

Public Relations overlaps with, and is sometimes confused with, several adjacent fields. Marketing is concerned primarily with the transactional relationship between organizations and customers; advertising with the paid placement of controlled messages in mediated channels; propaganda with the deliberate orientation of belief and behavior, typically in conditions of asymmetric information and frequently in political or wartime contexts; corporate communication with the integrated communicative function of the firm as a whole; and strategic communication with the alignment of communicative activity to organizational strategy across all functional silos [57–59].

The boundaries are porous and contested. Marketing PR, integrated marketing communications, and content-driven branded media have blurred the clear distinction between PR and marketing. Public diplomacy, government communication and strategic communication have blurred the distinction between PR and propaganda in international and security contexts. These overlaps are partly a matter of shared tactics and tools and partly a matter of how the communicative function is conceived as a whole. In the strategic communication tradition associated with Holtzhausen and Zerfass, PR is treated as one of several communicative functions integrated under a single organizational strategy. Public Relations scholarship, by contrast, has generally defended PR as a distinct field of study. On this view, PR has its own frameworks of practice and its own understanding of communicative reality, and crucially a role that exceeds the organizational arena and extends into democratic life [60–62].

4. Theoretical Foundations

The theoretical landscape of Public Relations is plural and contested. No single paradigm commands the field; the major frameworks coexist, partly compete, and partly address different layers of the same phenomenon. This section surveys the principal theoretical traditions, mentioned in Table 1, in the order in which they have entered the disciplinary debate, identifying what each contributes and what each excludes [63].

Table 1. Major theoretical frameworks in Public Relations.

Framework	Core Proposition	Key Theorists	Primary Critique
Excellence Theory	PR adds organizational value when it is a strategic management function practicing symmetrical, two-way communication aimed at mutual understanding.	J. Grunig; L. Grunig; Dozier	Presupposes an appetite for symmetry; abstracts away power asymmetries; the symmetrical ideal is empirically a minority practice.
Situational Theory of Publics	Publics can be segmented and predicted from problem recognition, constraint recognition and involvement.	J. Grunig; Kim and Grunig	Behavioral–cognitive focus; thin on power, meaning and how issues are socially constructed.
Relationship Management	The object of PR is the organization/public relationship itself—trust, commitment, satisfaction, control mutuality—not the message.	Ledingham and Bruning; Hon and Grunig	Imports interpersonal-relationship metaphors at organizational scale; treats relationships as bilateral, not networked.

Table 1. *Cont.*

Framework	Core Proposition	Key Theorists	Primary Critique
Dialogic Theory	Ethical PR rests on genuine dialogue: mutuality, propinquity, empathy, risk, commitment—not one-way information.	Kent and Taylor	Normative conditions are rarely met under real power constraints; dialogic potential vs. monologic practice.
Contingency Theory	PR stances fall on an advocacy–accommodation continuum; the stance is contingent on many internal and external variables.	Cancel; Cameron; et al.	Descriptive more than predictive; the large variable set resists operationalization; thin normative guidance.
Rhetorical and Discursive	Organizations are rhetorical actors that build, circulate and contest meaning through argument, narrative and symbolic action.	Heath; Botan and Hazleton	Can over-credit persuasive agency; less attention to structural power and to measurable outcomes.
Critical and Sociological	PR is a social and political practice embedded in power, ideology, class, gender and race—not reducible to organizational utility.	L’Etang and Pieczka; Edwards; Motion	Strong on critique, lighter on prescriptive guidance for practice.
Legitimacy-oriented	PR is the communicative achievement through which legitimate authority is publicly produced and contested (pragmatic, moral, cognitive legitimacy).	Suchman and Beetham (foundations); Simões (political-mediation lineage); emerging PR scholarship	Still emerging; lacks the consolidated empirical infrastructure of the established traditions.

4.1. The Excellence Theory

The Excellence Theory, developed by James Grunig and colleagues through the IABC-funded research program of the late 1980s and 1990s, remains the most widely cited theoretical framework in the field [64]. Its core proposition is that PR contributes to organizational effectiveness when it is structured as a strategic management function, when it gives publics the capacity to influence organizational decision making, and when it operates through symmetrical two-way communication aimed at mutual understanding [65].

The Excellence Theory rests on the four models formulated by Grunig and Hunt in 1984. The press agency/publicity model is one-way communication oriented to propaganda. The public information model is one-way communication oriented to the dissemination of accurate information. The two-way asymmetrical model is two-way communication used to persuade publics to align with the organization. The two-way symmetrical model, presented as the normative apex of the typology, is two-way communication oriented to mutual understanding and reciprocal adaptation between organization and publics [66].

The Excellence Theory’s historical contribution to the consolidation of PR as a research discipline is not in dispute. It gave the field a developmental narrative, an empirical research program, a set of operational measures, and a normative direction. Its limitations are also not in dispute. The model presupposes an organizational interest in symmetrical engagement that is often not present. It abstracts away the structural asymmetries of power within which PR operates. Its normative apex, the symmetrical model, is a regulative ideal borrowed from the Habermasian theory of communicative action without the philosophical conditions that give the ideal its critical force; the result is a normative framework that empirical work has repeatedly shown to be a minority practice even within organizations that publicly claim it [67–69].

4.2. *The Situational Theory of Publics*

Developed by Grunig in parallel with the Excellence Theory, the Situational Theory of Publics (STP) provides an empirical instrument for segmenting publics according to their communicative behavior [70]. STP distinguishes publics along three independent variables: problem recognition, constraint recognition, and level of involvement. The combination of these variables yields four types of publics: nonpublics, latent publics, aware publics, and active publics whose communication behavior differs systematically and predictably [71].

STP has been refined and extended through the Situational Theory of Problem Solving (STOPS), developed by Kim and Grunig, which integrates the original framework with cognitive and behavioral variables drawn from problem-solving research [72]. Both versions of the situational tradition share an empirical, segmentation-oriented orientation that has been particularly influential in health, environmental, and risk communication research [73].

4.3. *Relationship Management*

Relationship Management theory, articulated principally by Ledingham and Bruning from the late 1990s onward, reframes the object of PR as the organization-public relationship itself rather than as the communication process [74]. The shift is conceptually significant: it positions the quality of the relationship, measured along dimensions such as trust, commitment, satisfaction, and control mutuality, as the proper outcome variable of PR activity [75]. Hon and Grunig's relationship quality scales operationalized these dimensions and have been widely used in empirical research [76].

Relationship Management converged in the early 2000s with co-orientation models, with stakeholder theory, and with social-exchange perspectives, to constitute what is sometimes called the "relational turn" in PR scholarship. The framework has been criticized for its conceptual reliance on interpersonal relationship metaphors when applied to large organizational settings, and for its tendency to treat relationships as bilateral when they are typically multi-party and networked [77].

4.4. *Dialogic Theory*

The Dialogic Theory of Public Relations, formulated by Kent and Taylor in 1998 and developed through their subsequent work, grounds the discipline in a normative account of dialogue drawn from Buber, Bakhtin, Gadamer and the broader hermeneutic and existential tradition [78]. Kent and Taylor proposed five dialogic principles-mutuality, propinquity, empathy, risk and commitment-as conditions for genuinely dialogic communication. The theory has been particularly influential in the analysis of organizational websites and social media, where the gap between dialogic potential and monological practice is often striking [79].

Dialogic theory has been criticized, like the symmetrical model with which it shares philosophical ancestry, for the difficulty of meeting its normative conditions under real organizational and power constraints. Its more recent versions emphasize dialogue as an ethical orientation and a regulative ideal rather than as a directly achievable communicative state [80].

4.5. *Contingency Theory*

Contingency Theory, developed by Cancel, Cameron and colleagues in the late 1990s, was formulated as an alternative to the prescriptive ambitions of the symmetrical model [81]. It posits that PR practice can be located along a continuum from pure advocacy to pure accommodation, and that the position taken by an organization in any given situation is contingent on a large set of internal and external variables, including organizational

characteristics, the nature of the public, the issue at stake, the legal and regulatory environment, and the cultural context [82]. The contingency tradition has been productive in crisis communication, public affairs and conflict management, where the symmetrical ideal is most evidently inapplicable [83].

4.6. *Rhetorical and Discursive Approaches*

The rhetorical tradition in Public Relations, associated principally with Heath, Botan and Hazleton, treats organizations as rhetorical actors that participate in the public construction of meaning through argument, narrative and symbolic action [84,85]. Rhetorical PR draws on the classical and the new-rhetorical traditions (Burke, Perelman, Toulmin) to analyze how organizations make claims, how those claims circulate in public discourse, and how they are accepted, modified, or contested by relevant publics [86].

The rhetorical tradition has been a central counterweight to the managerial orientation of the Excellence paradigm, recovering for PR scholarship a vocabulary capable of describing the field's actual discursive operations. It converges with discourse-analytic approaches that examine the construction of organizational identity, legitimacy and responsibility through textual and intertextual practice [87].

4.7. *Critical, Sociological and Legitimacy-Oriented Approaches*

Critical Public Relations scholarship emerged from the 1990s onward, principally in Europe and the Commonwealth countries, as a sustained engagement with the questions of power, ideology, identity and social inequality that the dominant managerial paradigms had marginalized [88]. The work of L'Etang and Pieczka, of Edwards, Motion, Demetrious, Daymon and others, has examined PR as a social phenomenon embedded in structures of class, gender, race and political domination, drawing on Foucault, Bourdieu, Gramsci, and contemporary critical theory [89–91].

Critical PR is a heterogeneous tradition rather than a single school. Its unifying commitment is to the analysis of PR as a form of social and political practice whose consequences are not exhausted by its organizational utility. Its contributions have been particularly significant in opening the field to questions of activism, social movements, decolonial perspectives, and the political economy of professional practice [92,93]. The most important practical effect of the critical tradition has been to disrupt the assumption, implicit in much mainstream PR writing, that the legitimate object of the discipline is the organization and its strategic interest. Critical scholarship reframes the field as a site at which the relationships between organizations, publics and the broader institutional order are negotiated, and at which the distribution of communicative resources within that order is decided.

Within and adjacent to this critical tradition, a more recent and still emerging line of inquiry reframes the central object of Public Relations as legitimacy rather than just communication. Drawing on Weberian sociology, on Suchman's typology of pragmatic, moral and cognitive legitimacy, on Beetham's three-dimensional account and on contemporary institutional theory, this line of work treats PR not as a process to be managed but as the communicative achievement through which the belief in legitimate authority is publicly produced and contested [94–96]. A genealogically distinct but converging line of analysis has been developed within Latin American scholarship since the 1980s: Roberto Porto Simões's Political Theory of Public conceives PR as a political function of mediation between organizations and their publics, anticipating, from a non-Anglo-American tradition, several of the structural moves the legitimacy-oriented approach now formalizes [31,32]. This is not yet a consolidated framework with the empirical infrastructure of the Excellence, situational or relational traditions. It is an active site of theoretical development whose

specific contribution is to position legitimacy as the central analytical category, and to read the established frameworks of the discipline as partial answers to a problem they do not always fully name [97].

5. Models and Approaches to Practice

The translation of theory into practice has, in Public Relations, taken the form of a small number of recurring process models. The most durable of these is the four-step Research-Planning-Communication-Evaluation (RPCE) cycle popularized by Cutlip and Center, sometimes presented as ROPE (Research-Objectives-Programming-Evaluation) or RACE (Research-Action-Communication-Evaluation) [98,99]. The variations are minor; the underlying logic is constant: practice begins from situational research, advances through the formulation of strategy and tactics, executes through the production and placement of communicative actions, and closes through the evaluation of outcomes against objectives.

The strategic management approach, developed within the Excellence tradition and refined in subsequent work, situates the RPCE cycle within a broader account of how PR contributes to organizational decision making [100]. In this approach, PR participates in the strategic planning of the organization, identifies the publics whose support or opposition affects strategic outcomes, designs communication programs that align with strategic objectives, and reports on the contribution of PR activity to organizational performance through frameworks such as the Barcelona Principles for measurement and evaluation [101].

Stakeholder theory, originally formulated by Freeman in the management literature, has been progressively integrated into PR practice through the recognition that organizations are accountable to a plurality of constituencies whose claims are not reducible to shareholder value [102]. Stakeholder mapping, prioritization matrices, and engagement plans have become standard instruments of professional work. The integration has been particularly visible in corporate social responsibility (CSR), environmental, social and governance (ESG) communication, and sustainability reporting, where PR functions as both the producer of stakeholder-oriented narratives and the manager of stakeholder consultation processes [103,104].

Reputation management has emerged, particularly since the 2000s, as a dominant framework for the strategic positioning of PR within the organization. Drawing on Fombrun's reputational capital framework, on the RepTrak instrument, and on the broader corporate reputation literature, this approach treats reputation as a measurable strategic asset whose construction and protection is the central business case for PR [105,106]. Critics have argued that the reputation framework risks subordinating the broader civic and democratic functions of PR to a narrow asset-management logic; defenders respond that it gives the field the strategic vocabulary required to secure its place at the executive table [107].

Measurement and evaluation of PR activity have developed into a distinct sub-field since the early 2000s. The Barcelona Principles, first adopted in 2010 and revised through successive iterations to version 3.0 in 2020, codify the international consensus on PR measurement: programs should be measured against pre-defined objectives, outcomes rather than outputs are the proper unit of evaluation, business results and communication outcomes should both be measured, and the use of Advertising Value Equivalents (AVEs) as a measurement of communication value is rejected as analytically invalid [101]. Macnamara's models for the evaluation of public communication, AMEC's Integrated Evaluation Framework, and the broader work of the International Association for Measurement and Evaluation of Communication have established the operational vocabulary of contemporary measurement practice [108,109]. Persistent challenges include the attribution of organizational outcomes to communication activity in the presence of multiple causal factors, the measurement of intangible relational and reputational assets, and the

long-standing tension between the evaluation demands of short-term campaigns and the genuinely cumulative nature of relationship and legitimacy work [110].

6. Functional Areas of Practice

Contemporary Public Relations is structured around a set of functional areas that are increasingly specialized. The boundaries between them are porous and many practitioners work across several, but the differentiation is sharp enough to sustain distinct sub-fields of practice, research and professional accreditation [111].

6.1. Media Relations

Media relations remain, in most professional contexts, the historically dominant function of PR. It covers the cultivation of relationships with journalists and editors, the production of press releases and media kits, the management of press conferences and embargoes, the placement of feature material, and the increasingly demanding work of managing organizational visibility across a fragmented media environment in which the boundaries between earned, owned, paid and shared media have collapsed [112,113]. The decline of traditional newsrooms and the rise in platform-based news distribution have transformed but not eliminated the media-relations function, which has expanded to include direct platform engagement and influencer relations [114].

6.2. Internal and Employee Communication

Internal communication has emerged from a peripheral administrative function in the 1980s into one of the central concerns of contemporary PR. Its functions include the alignment of employees with organizational strategy, the construction of organizational culture and identity, the management of internal change processes, the support of employee engagement and well-being, and the increasingly recognized role of employees as external brand ambassadors and as primary sources of organizational legitimacy in the public sphere [115,116]. The field draws conceptually on organizational communication research, on the work of Welch and Jackson on stakeholder-oriented internal communication, on Men's research on authentic leadership and transparent communication, and on the broader employee engagement literature. The professional integration of internal communication into PR varies considerably across organizations: in many corporations it sits within human resources or in a separate corporate communication function; in others it is fully integrated into the PR or strategic communication department [117].

Three developments have reshaped internal communication practice since the late 2010s. The first is the consolidation of the employee as a primary external communicator, through the mechanism of social media; the boundary between internal and external communication has become operationally indistinct in organizations whose employees publish about their working lives on professional and personal platforms. The second is the integration of internal communication with diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives, with sustainability reporting on workforce conditions, and with the management of organizational responses to politically and socially charged events. The third is the operational consequence of hybrid and remote work for the maintenance of organizational culture and the communicative cohesion of dispersed teams [118].

6.3. Government Relations, Public Affairs and Lobbying

Government relations and public affairs comprise the PR work directed at policy-makers, regulators, parliaments and governmental institutions. The functions include the monitoring of legislative and regulatory developments, the formulation and advocacy of policy positions, the management of relationships with elected officials and civil servants, the participation in formal consultations, and the regulated practice of lobbying [119,120].

The field operates under increasing transparency requirements-the European Union's Transparency Register and equivalent national registers, the United States Lobbying Disclosure Act-that have professionalized but not depoliticized the activity [121].

6.4. Crisis Communication

Crisis communication has consolidated as one of the most developed sub-fields of PR research and practice. Coombs's Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) organizes primary response strategies into three postures-denial, diminishment and rebuilding-calibrated to the perceived organizational responsibility for the crisis, with a secondary set of bolstering strategies (reminder, ingratiation, victimage) deployed to reinforce the primary response. The framework provides the dominant analytical instrument in the field [122]. Crisis communication research has also drawn on Image Repair Theory (Benoit), Discourse of Renewal theory (Seeger, Sellnow, Ulmer), and on the Contingency Theory of crisis response [123]. The professional infrastructure for crisis management includes crisis manuals, dark sites, simulation exercises, and dedicated crisis teams, and is increasingly tested by the speed and reach of social-platform amplification [124].

6.5. Financial and Investor Relations

Investor relations occupy a specialized position within the broader PR field, governed by the regulatory frameworks of financial markets and oriented to the analytical needs of institutional investors, analysts and rating agencies. Its functions include the production of corporate disclosures, the management of earnings communications, the organization of investor days, and the support of the chief financial officer and chief executive in their communicative role within capital markets. The integration of ESG considerations into investment criteria has expanded the boundaries of the function in the last decade [125,126].

6.6. Marketing Public Relations

Marketing PR applies PR techniques to the support of marketing objectives-product launches, brand-building, content marketing, influencer partnerships, and the management of brand reputation in customer-facing contexts. The field has consolidated under the broader rubric of integrated marketing communications and, more recently, of brand storytelling and content-driven engagement. Its practitioners are increasingly drawn from cross-disciplinary backgrounds and the line that once separated marketing PR from advertising has become operationally indistinct in many digital contexts [127,128].

6.7. Community Relations and CSR Communication

Community relations is the older formulation of what has become, since the 1990s, the broader field of corporate social responsibility (CSR) and sustainability communication. The function manages the organization's relationships with the communities in which it operates, the construction and communication of its social and environmental commitments, and the increasingly demanding requirements of non-financial disclosure-from the GRI standards to the European Sustainability Reporting Standards adopted under the Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive [129–131].

6.8. Political Public Relations

Political Public Relations, defined by Strömbäck and Kioussis as the management of communication by political actors-parties, candidates, governments, interest groups-for the purpose of influencing relationships with publics relevant to their political goals, has consolidated as a distinct sub-field with its own scholarly infrastructure since the 2010s [132]. Its functions include campaign communication, government communication, party press operations, the strategic management of leader image, parliamentary communication,

and the management of relationships with media, voters, activists and organized interests [133]. The field draws simultaneously on PR, political communication and political marketing, and has been a particularly active site for the integration of legitimacy-oriented and representational analysis [134,135].

Political Public Relations is theoretically distinctive because the object of its work is the construction of political legitimacy itself, rather than the construction of organizational legitimacy under conditions of competitive market or regulatory pressure. The political actor cannot retreat to a non-political identity; the persistent task of the function is the continuous reconstruction of the conditions under which a representative claim is recognized as legitimate by those over whom authority is exercised. This places Political PR at the intersection of the empirical research on campaign communication, the normative literature on democratic representation, and the institutional analysis of the public sphere within which representation is performed.

6.9. Digital and Social Media Public Relations

Digital and social media PR is now less a separate functional area than a transversal condition of all PR work. It nevertheless retains a distinct operational profile, covering the management of organizational presence across multiple platforms (Facebook, Instagram, X, TikTok, LinkedIn, YouTube and emerging entrants), the operation of paid-and-organic content strategies under conditions of algorithmic curation, the work of search engine optimization and search engine reputation management, the management of online reviews, and the rapidly developing field of community management. The most active recent developments concern the integration of influencer relations and creator economies, the management of organizational presence under conditions of platform fragmentation and migration, and the operational integration of generative AI tools [136–138].

6.10. Activist, NGO and Social Movement Communication

The communicative practice of activist organizations, non-governmental organizations, civil society groups and social movements constitutes a distinct functional area whose disciplinary status within PR has historically been contested. For much of the twentieth century, the mainstream PR literature treated activists as “publics” to be managed by organizations rather than as communicative actors in their own right. The work of Demetrious, Coombs and Holladay, Henderson, Smith and others, from the 1990s onward, has progressively reframed activism and social movement communication as a legitimate object and a legitimate practice of PR [89,139]. The field examines how activist organizations construct their public legitimacy under conditions of resource asymmetry, how they mobilize supporters across digital and offline channels, how they navigate the relationships with media, donors, regulators and counter-movements, and how they manage the recurring tension between professionalization and grassroots authenticity. NGO communication operates under a partly distinct set of constraints-donor accountability, accreditation regimes, the increasingly demanding requirements of impact reporting-that have produced a substantial professional infrastructure of its own [140].

7. Professional Infrastructure

The professional infrastructure of Public Relations comprises associations, codes of conduct, educational programs, accreditation systems, and the broader industrial structure of agencies and in-house departments through which the work is organized [141].

7.1. National and International Associations

The principal international bodies are the International Public Relations Association (IPRA), founded in 1955, and the Global Alliance for Public Relations and Communication

Management, founded in 2000 as an umbrella of national associations. Major national associations include the Public Relations Society of America (PRSA), the Chartered Institute of Public Relations (CIPR) in the United Kingdom, the Deutsche Public Relations Gesellschaft (DPRG) in Germany, the Public Relations Consultants Association (PRCA) of the United Kingdom, the Canadian Public Relations Society (CPRS), and the regional EUPRERA in Europe, alongside dozens of national professional bodies on every continent [142,143].

7.2. Codes of Ethics

Professional codes of ethics, beginning with the IPRA Code of Athens of 1965 and the Code of Lisbon of 1978, codify the normative expectations of the profession. The current Global Alliance Code of Ethics, the PRSA Code of Ethics, the CIPR Code, and the national equivalents converge on a small set of core commitments: honesty, transparency about clients and interests, the avoidance of conflicts of interest, the protection of confidential information, the duty of loyalty to clients and employers, and the broader responsibility to the public interest [144,145]. Enforcement varies; in most jurisdictions adherence to professional codes is contractual rather than statutory, and the regulation of lobbying is generally separate from the regulation of PR practice more broadly [146].

7.3. Education, Accreditation and Research

Public Relations education is provided at undergraduate and postgraduate level by hundreds of universities worldwide. Accreditation bodies, such as the PRSA-affiliated Certification in Education for Public Relations (CEPR), the CIPR's accreditation program, and the European EUPRERA quality benchmarks, attempt to standardize curricular content [147]. Research production is concentrated in a small set of established journals—Public Relations Review, Journal of Public Relations Research, Public Relations Inquiry, Journal of Communication Management, International Journal of Strategic Communication—and in a growing periphery of specialized outlets in political communication, corporate communication, crisis communication and digital media [148].

7.4. Industrial Structure

The PR industry is structured around three principal forms: independent agencies (ranging from global networks such as Edelman, BCW, Weber Shandwick, FleishmanHillard and Hill+Knowlton to thousands of mid-size and boutique firms), in-house departments within corporations, governments and non-profits, and the rapidly expanding category of consultancy work undertaken by independent practitioners. The global PR industry has been valued at over USD 100 billion in annual revenues and continues to grow, though the boundaries with adjacent fields—digital marketing, content production, influencer management, corporate consultancy—complicate the measurement [149,150].

8. Digital Transformation and Artificial Intelligence

The digital transformation of Public Relations has been continuous since the mid-1990s, but its character has shifted across at least three distinct phases. The first, from the mid-1990s to the mid-2000s, was characterized by the migration of established PR practices to web channels: corporate websites, online press rooms, email distribution of releases, and the early management of online news visibility. The second, from approximately 2005 to 2020, was defined by the rise in social platforms and the recognition that platform logics—algorithmic curation, virality, attention economies, networked publics—had reshaped the structural conditions of professional work [151,152]. The third, which began around 2022 with the diffusion of generative AI, is still in its early stages and is reshaping the practice of PR more rapidly than any preceding technological inflection [153].

8.1. *The Hybrid Media System*

Chadwick's analysis of the hybrid media system, in which older and newer media logics interact in complex feedback loops, has provided the most influential conceptual framework for understanding the contemporary operational environment of PR [154]. In this environment, the production and circulation of news is the joint product of legacy newsrooms, platform-mediated user-generated content, and the systematic communicative activity of organizational actors. PR practitioners operate simultaneously across multiple logics-newsroom logic, platform logic, search logic, influencer logic-and the management of consistency, timing and authenticity across these logics has become a central operational challenge [155].

8.2. *Influencers, Creator Economies and Earned Media*

The rise in social-media influencers and the broader creator economy has reconfigured the distinction between earned, paid and owned media. Influencer relations is now a significant operational area for both consumer and political PR, with its own professional infrastructure of agencies, platforms, contractual arrangements and disclosure requirements [156]. The boundary with advertising is regulated in most jurisdictions by consumer protection authorities, and the boundary with political communication is increasingly addressed by electoral and platform regulation [157].

8.3. *Algorithmic Visibility and Platform Governance*

The condition of algorithmic visibility-the fact that the reach of organizational communication is mediated by recommendation systems whose criteria are opaque to the communicator-has become a defining structural condition of contemporary PR. Search engine optimization, social-platform optimization, and the broader work of platform-specific content design now constitute a substantial share of professional practice [158]. The recognition that platform governance-the rules by which platforms moderate content, label political advertising, prioritize sources, and respond to disinformation-is a primary determinant of communicative outcomes has progressively integrated platform-policy expertise into the PR function [159,160].

8.4. *Generative Artificial Intelligence in PR Practice*

Generative AI is being integrated into PR practice at an accelerating pace. Documented uses include first-draft writing of press releases, media advisories and social content; media monitoring and sentiment analysis at scale; the simulation of stakeholder responses to draft communications; the personalization of content for segmented audiences; the production of multilingual variants; the support of media-relations workflows through automated journalist matching; and the increasing use of AI agents for routine engagement [161,162]. The professional debate has converged on a small set of recurring concerns: the verification of factual content produced by AI systems, the disclosure of AI involvement to publics, the management of the reputational and legal risks of AI-generated errors, the ethical implications of synthetic media including voice clones and deepfakes, and the broader questions of authorship, authenticity and trust in a communicative environment in which the human or non-human origin of content is no longer self-evident [163,164].

Industry surveys from 2023 to 2025 indicate that the majority adoption of generative AI tools for at least some PR tasks has occurred across most major markets, with corresponding concerns about workforce displacement, skills transformation, and the proper governance of AI use within the profession [165,166]. The emerging academic literature on AI in PR-encompassing work by Galloway and Swiatek on the ethical and operational implications, by Yue and Men on AI-mediated engagement with publics, by Buhmann and White on the

role and disciplinary implications of AI, by Bourne on AI and pedagogy, and by Pavlik on the broader transformation of communication work-has begun to consolidate the field's intellectual response to the technological inflection [43,162,167–169]. The integration of AI into PR is, at the time of writing, the most active site of operational, ethical and theoretical development in the field.

Three structural questions remain open. The first concerns the relationship between the speed of AI-mediated content production and the slower temporality of trust-building, which is the proper economy of PR work; the asymmetry between the two creates a recurring risk of generating reputational liabilities faster than they can be managed. The second concerns the displacement of routine production tasks toward automation and the consequent reorganization of professional skill around judgment, ethical evaluation, contextual interpretation, and relationship management, which are the components of PR work least susceptible to automation. The third concerns the broader transformation of the public sphere itself, in which the human or non-human origin of communicative content is no longer reliably identifiable, and in which the foundations of public trust must be reconstructed under conditions that prior PR theory did not anticipate [170,171].

9. Critical Perspectives and Contemporary Debates

Several long-standing and several recent debates structure the contemporary intellectual life of the field. They do not divide it into clean camps; the same practitioners and scholars often hold positions across several of them. The most significant are reviewed here in summary form [172].

9.1. *PR and Democracy: Civic Function or Manufactured Consent?*

The deepest disagreement in the field concerns the relation between Public Relations and democratic life. Three positions remain in play. The first, traceable to Lippmann and to elements of the Bernaysian tradition and reformulated by contemporary critical scholars, reads PR as an instrument for the engineering of consent-an asymmetric production of public opinion in favor of organized interests with the resources to deploy it [173,174]. The second, traceable to Dewey, to the European public-sphere tradition, and to relational and dialogic theorists, reads PR as an instrument of democratic deliberation-the communicative coordination of complex societies in which organizations and publics must continuously negotiate their mutual claims [175,176]. The third, advanced within the emerging legitimacy-oriented tradition, treats PR as the communicative practice through which the legitimacy of public actors is publicly constructed under conditions that are neither purely manipulative nor purely deliberative. The question this third position presses is structural: which conditions determine when a legitimacy claim succeeds and when it fails [177].

9.2. *Power, Ideology and the Critical Tradition*

Building on the critical tradition introduced in Section 4.7, this scholarship sustains a continuous interrogation of the ideological work performed by mainstream theoretical frameworks. The Excellence Theory has been read as a depoliticizing framework that conceals power asymmetries beneath the language of mutual benefit; the dialogic tradition has been read as importing a normative ideal whose conditions are systematically absent in the contexts where it is most invoked; reputation management has been read as the subordination of civic communication to asset-management logic. The critical tradition does not propose a single replacement theory but a continuous demand that the field account for the structural conditions of its own practice [178–180].

9.3. Diversity, Decolonial and Indigenous Perspectives

The recognition that the dominant theoretical and historical narratives of the field have been produced from a narrow set of Anglo-American institutional contexts has, in the last decade, generated a substantial body of work that seeks to provincialize the field's self-understanding (see also Section 2.4). Research on PR in African, Asian, Latin American, Indigenous and post-colonial contexts has documented the existence of communicative practices and traditions that the mainstream historiography systematically excludes [181,182]. Decolonial scholarship has interrogated the assumptions about organizational form, public sphere, and professional ethics that the dominant frameworks treat as universal but that are demonstrably particular to a Western modernist tradition [183].

9.4. Ethics in a Post-Truth, Platform-Mediated Environment

The ethical foundations of PR are being substantially renegotiated under the pressure of post-truth political dynamics, of platform-driven disinformation, of the integration of generative AI into routine practice, and of growing public skepticism toward professional communicative actors of all kinds. The classical ethical commitments of the profession—honesty, transparency, accountability—remain operative but require renewed operational specification under conditions in which the verification of authorship, the authenticity of content, and the integrity of public discourse are themselves at stake [184–186].

9.5. The Convergence with Strategic Communication

The progressive consolidation of strategic communication as a broader disciplinary framework, covering PR alongside corporate communication, advertising, marketing communication, internal communication and public diplomacy, raises an ongoing question about the disciplinary autonomy of Public Relations, extending the boundary discussion in Section 3.3. Some scholars treat strategic communication as the proper successor framework that integrates the previously fragmented communicative functions of organizations; others insist on the distinctive theoretical and ethical commitments of PR—its orientation to publics rather than markets, its commitment to mutuality rather than transaction, its democratic rather than purely managerial vocation—as grounds for the preservation of its disciplinary autonomy [187–189].

10. Current Status and Future Directions

Public Relations enters the late 2020s as a paradoxical field: simultaneously larger, more professionalized, and more technically sophisticated than at any point in its history, and simultaneously more contested in its purpose, more uncertain in its theoretical foundations, and more exposed to the structural transformations of the public sphere within which it operates. Five developments are likely to define its evolution over the coming decade [190].

First, the integration of generative AI will continue to reshape the operational profile of the field, displacing routine production tasks toward automation while increasing the relative weight of judgment, ethical evaluation, relationship work and contextual understanding within professional practice. The reorganization of PR work around human–AI collaboration is the most visible transformation under way [191].

Second, the structural transformation of the public sphere—the fragmentation of audiences, the algorithmic mediation of attention, the erosion of trust in institutions of all kinds, the rise in polarization, and the increasingly contested status of factual claims in political discourse—will continue to challenge the assumptions of mid-twentieth-century PR theory. The frameworks that presupposed a stable mass audience addressable through a limited

set of media channels are inadequate to a communicative environment in which audience, channel and message are all in continuous reconfiguration [192].

Third, the demand for accountability, transparency and demonstrated contribution to organizational and social outcomes will continue to grow. The Barcelona Principles for measurement, the consolidation of ESG and sustainability reporting standards, the requirements of transparency registers for lobbying, and the broader expectation that PR claims be evidence-based will continue to professionalize the field while exposing it to the limits of measurement [108,109].

Fourth, the field's engagement with questions of democracy, legitimacy and representation is likely to deepen, particularly in the political and institutional sub-fields. The recognition that organizations and public actors operate within a structural condition of legitimacy that their communication is called upon to sustain or repair is reshaping the theoretical agenda of the discipline, and the integration of legitimacy-oriented analysis with the established frameworks is one of the most productive sites of contemporary research [34,35].

Fifth, the geographical and cultural broadening of the field will continue. The growth of PR scholarship and practice outside the Anglo-American core, the integration of decolonial and indigenous perspectives into the disciplinary conversation, and the consolidation of distinct regional traditions—Continental European, Latin American, Asian, African—are reshaping the field's self-understanding in ways whose full theoretical implications are still being worked out [193].

11. Conclusions

Public Relations is a field of practice older than its professional name and an academic discipline younger than its principal concepts. The work itself has not changed in substance for a century: the production of organizational visibility, the management of relationships with publics whose recognition the organization cannot do without, and the communicative labor through which legitimacy is constructed and contested. What has changed is the scale, the speed and the conditions under which that work is performed.

Theoretically, the field is plural. The Excellence Theory consolidated PR as a research discipline and remains the most widely cited framework. The relational, dialogic, situational, contingent, rhetorical, critical and legitimacy-oriented traditions have each contributed distinct conceptual resources without converging on a single paradigm. On the reading this entry has advanced, the plurality is not a weakness to be resolved through future synthesis but the analytical signature of a phenomenon—the communicative production of legitimacy under conditions of structural asymmetry—that does not admit a single reduction.

Practically, the field is undergoing its largest transformation since the mid-twentieth century. Generative artificial intelligence, the algorithmic mediation of attention, the erosion of institutional trust and the renewed scrutiny of the democratic role of organized communication are reshaping the conditions of the work. The professional infrastructure of associations, codes, accreditation and education is adapting with characteristic delay.

What persists across the changes is the centrality of the function. As long as organizations and public actors depend on the recognition of publics whose attention is scarce, whose trust is contingent and whose consent must be renegotiated, there will be a discipline whose task is to understand how that recognition is produced and contested. Public Relations is the name the twentieth century gave to that discipline. The twenty-first century is reshaping what the name covers, not the necessity of the function it names.

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